least fuelled, by the refugee crisis. And in his address to the twenty-second congress of the CPSU on 17 October, Khrushchev withdrew his ultimatum to unilaterally sign a peace treaty with East Germany by the end of 1961.

However, in little more than a week after this concession, a new crisis brought the US and the Soviets 'toe-to-toe' in potential armed conflict. For sixteen hours on 27–28 October 1961, US and Soviet tanks sides deployed on either side of the Friedrichstrasse crossing point. Some officials believe that this confrontation was more dangerous than the Cuban missile crisis a year later. Paul Nitze, then Assistant Secretary of Defense for International Security Affairs, later argued there was greater risk of armed conflict with the Soviet Union over Berlin in October 1961 than over Cuba in October 1962 (though this also reflected his view that the risk of war in 1962 was greatly exaggerated).[35] Valentin Falin, a senior foreign policy aide involved in the Kremlin's handling of the Berlin crisis, believed that the crisis in October 1961 was the most dangerous confrontation of the Cold War.[36]

'Apart from that, Mrs Lincoln, what did you think of the play?'

On 13 August 1961 all but seven of the existing crossing points between East and West Berlin were closed. The crossing at Friedrichstrasse, which become immortalised in the West as 'Checkpoint Charlie,' soon entered the iconography of the Cold War. On 22 October 1961 the assistant chief of the US Mission in Berlin, Allan Lightner, and his wife, Dorothy, decided to indulge their passion for the arts, in what became the most potentially momentous trip to the theatre since Abraham and Mary Lincoln went to see *Our American Cousin* in Washington on 14 April 1865.

To reach the State Opera House in East Berlin, Allan and Dorothy needed to pass through Checkpoint Charlie. The Berlin Wall had done nothing to alter the rights of the occupying forces to move around the city. Soviet officials were also entitled to inspect the papers of Western officials crossing between sectors. For East German officials, however, to do so would violate the Four Power Agreement. On 22 October 1961 East German *Volkspolizei* nevertheless insisted on inspecting the Lightner's passports. British officials had been willing to accept such intrusions. US